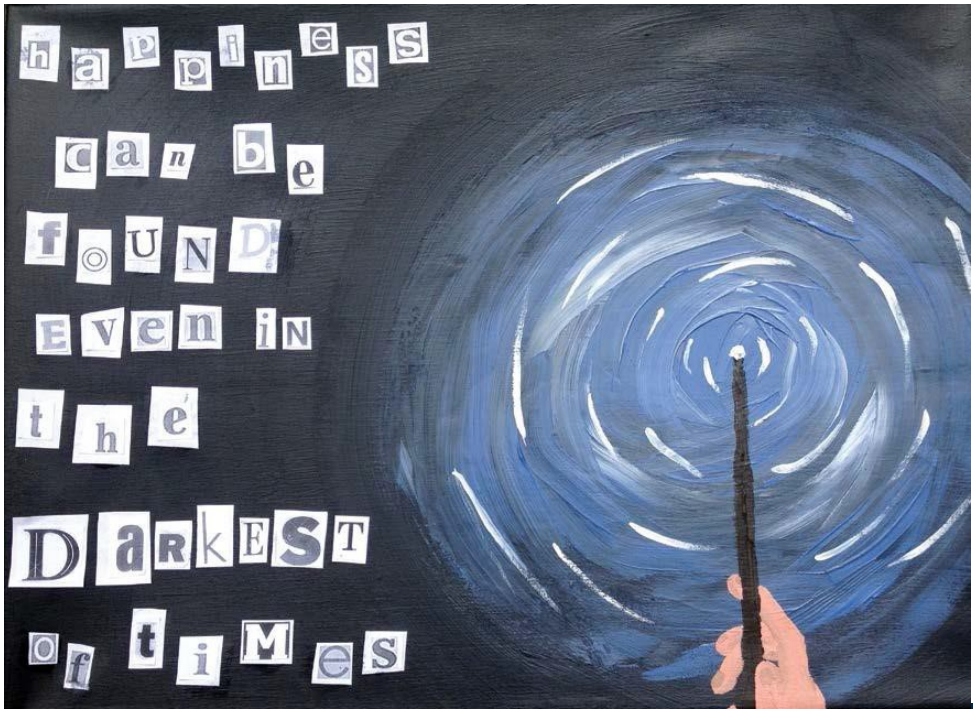




Adult Mental Health Team

Depression

A guide to help you cope

Recovery Focus

This booklet has been designed by experienced clinicians working with people who have a wide range of mental health conditions.

The North and West adult mental health team work collaboratively with people to help them cope with their symptoms. This way of working is called a recovery approach.

The workbook is arranged across four key sections:

Understand and recognise symptoms of depression	3
Use coping strategies to move forward	6
Explore your road to recovery	22
Deal with setbacks	27

1

Understand and recognise symptoms of depression

Questions to ask yourself

- Do you find that your mood is low for large periods of the day and you generally feel 'down in the dumps'?
- Have your energy levels and/or motivation to do things you previously enjoyed decreased?
- Do you often feel weepy or irritable?
- Do you feel that things are getting on top of you?
- Do you find that your confidence has reduced?
- Have you been experiencing suicidal thoughts?
- Has your sleep pattern changed?
- Has your appetite or concentration changed?

If the answer any of these questions is yes you may be experiencing symptoms of depression and you may find this booklet on depression helpful.

Everyone has times when they may feel low or feel like they can't be bothered. Depression is a more extreme form of this, lasting for an extended period of time.

When depressed, people also find that their motivation is low, their appetite changes, their sleeping patterns are disrupted and their concentration and memory are reduced. experiences include feeling irritable, weepy and isolated. People suffering with depression can also experience symptoms of anxiety.

Other typical experiences include feeling irritable, weepy and isolated. People suffering with depression can also experience symptoms of anxiety.

Depression is very common and no one is immune to it but depression is treatable. Those who experience it often talk of feeling stronger within themselves when they have overcome the symptoms.

Possible contributory factors

Loss

Loss can trigger depression. It could be following the death of someone close, a major life change (such as moving house or changing jobs), or simply moving from one phase of life into another, e.g. as you reach retirement or your children leave home. It's not just the negative experience that causes depression, but how we deal with it.

Traumatic life events

In many cases, the first time someone becomes depressed, it has been triggered by an unwelcome or traumatic event for example, loss of employment, divorce or following distress such as physical or sexual assault.

Biological reasons

Depression can have familial ties. If someone in your immediate family has experienced depression, there is an increased chance that you will develop similar feelings. It is therefore thought that our genetic make-up plays a role.

People's behaviour patterns also typically change if they are feeling low or depressed. They may tend to spend a lot of their time indoors, may not socialise as much as they used to. Daily activities may become difficult to complete, even getting out of bed in the morning can be exhausting.

It may be helpful to list what you have personally experienced in order to increase awareness of possible triggers.

2

Using coping strategies to move forward

Replacing negative behaviour patterns

Negative life events or experiences such as grief, trauma or daily stressors can make us feel low. This is a completely understandable and normal response to experience following significant life events

When we feel low our motivation to do things often decreases and we can find ourselves giving up hobbies or activities that we previously enjoyed. We may develop unhealthy coping strategies such as sleeping late into the afternoon, drug or alcohol use and social withdrawal in an attempt to avoid feeling low.

These unhealthy coping strategies provide temporary relief but ultimately result in us engaging in less pleasurable activities. These pleasurable activities are important in providing positive reinforcement. In the long term a lack of positive reinforcement can act to maintain depression.

By learning how to replace the negative behaviour patterns with new rewarding behaviours you can increase the amount of positive reinforcement you experience, reducing depression in the long term.

This section of the workbook will help you to focus on identifying your negative behaviour patterns and increasing the amount of positive reinforcement you experience. If you persist with positive activities then gradually these activities will become more pleasurable to engage in.

Examples of negative behaviour patterns

Can you relate to any of the negative behaviour patterns?

Cognitive avoidance

- Not thinking about relationship problems
- Not making decisions about the future
- Not taking opportunities
- Not being serious about work or education
- Ruminating on trying to explain the past or solve unsolvable problems.

Avoidance by distraction

- Playing computer games
- Gambling
- Comfort eating
- Excessive exercise.

Social withdrawal

- Not answering the phone
- Avoiding friends.

Non-social avoidance

- Not taking on challenging tasks
- Sitting around the house
- Spending excessive time in bed.

Identifying your negative behaviour patterns

Try to fill in your examples in this table. Think about the consequences that are a result of the negative behaviour pattern and consider how these behaviours may be maintaining a cycle of feeling low.

Negative behaviour	Immediate consequences (intended) Why did you carry out the behaviour?	Immediate consequences (unintended) How did you actually feel after the behaviour?	Response/ outcome
I sleep until noon nearly every day	I want to avoid feeling stressed and low	I missed breakfast, I have no time to exercise and I'm not keeping up with my daily responsibilities	Increased stress due to unmet responsibilities, feelings of guilt surrounding worsening health due to little exercise, reduced energy due to inadequate diet, leading to increased feelings of depression

Negative behaviour	Immediate consequences (intended) Why did you carry out the behaviour?	Immediate consequences (unintended) How did you actually feel after the behaviour?	Response/ outcome

Developing positive replacement behaviours

Now that you are able to identify the negative behaviour patterns that you use and understand how these behaviours may be maintaining a low mood, the next step is to replace these negative behaviours.

Fill in the following table with your own ideas for positive replacement behaviours.

Try to think about:

- **Socialising:** social contact often helps us feel better, even though you may not feel like it at the time
- **Hobbies and interests:** start something you have enjoyed in the past or a new project/interest
- **Exercise:** it doesn't have to be anything too energetic, just going for a walk regularly can be a good option
- **Bedtimes:** regular sleep patterns can improve mood and energy levels
- **Time for yourself:** it is important to have time to relax.

Once you have completed your list of ideas rate each activity in terms of how easy the activity is to complete.

Activity	Ease 0 = very hard 10 = very easy	Reward 0 = not rewarding 10 = very rewarding
Going for a walk	9	6

Implementing the positive behaviours

The next stage is to plan how and these positive activities will be completed. An activity schedule (see page 14) can be a useful way of doing this. Practice choosing specific days and times to complete activities from your list and try to stick to this as much as possible. Highlighting set times to complete your chosen activities can make it easier to stick to carry out the behaviour.

It is useful to consider possible obstacles and plan how you are going to carry out the activity. Spend some time planning out your week ahead, writing down the activities that you plan to carry out can be helpful.

Initially focus on scheduling in one or two activities that you previously rated easy to complete. As time goes on you can start to include rewarding activities which you rated as more difficult to complete.

Try activity scheduling yourself

For the next week:

- Use the activity schedule overleaf as a diary to keep track of everything that you do
- Plan time slots for completing any everyday responsibilities such as preparing food, housework and any appointments
- Select one or two positive replacement behaviours from your list and plan specific times to complete these
- Record the time that you get up and go to bed each day.

Moving forward

- Continue to plan your time using the weekly activity schedule (an additional copy can be found on page 28)
- Gradually introduce additional positive replacement activities from your list.

Activity schedule

	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday
What time did you get up?			
Breakfast			
Morning			
Lunch			
Afternoon			
Dinner			
Evening			
What time did you go to bed?			

Thursday	Friday	Saturday	Sunday

Distraction

Distraction is an effective technique for changing your mood. When you realise that you have become upset, choose to interrupt your negative mood by engaging in an activity. Doing this should require your full attention, or be so absorbing of your attention that you will forget yourself.

- Watch a film or TV show
- Read a book
- Play an instrument or listen to music
- Exercise
- Draw

Sometimes negative emotions can be overwhelming, and you really need a break from them. Distractions will stop you worrying temporarily, giving you a respite from your negative mood. Please note, distractions are not a cure for depression.

Facing the cause of your negative mood or accepting negative emotions could also be considered a method of healing.

You need to find a personally appropriate balance between dealing directly with such moods and escaping from them in order to have the best chance of healing.

Organisation

A very good way to distract yourself productively is to do something to organise your life. Typically, when you are feeling low you are also feeling out of control.

- Clean and order your living or work spaces
- Organise your personal calendar
- Handle your finances
- Structure your exercise routine.

Time spent building up your own personal sense of control and accomplishment may empower you, especially when you are feeling low.

Comedy and Humour

Another good way to distract yourself is to immerse yourself in comedy and humour, for example:

- Watch a funny film or TV show
- Listen to a favourite comedian's routine
- Read a funny book or magazine.

Humour helps improve your mood and may be associated with positive memories. It's a temporary effect, but it can be a relief. Laughing also has a relaxing effect, and will help to reduce body tension.

Challenge negative thinking

Depression puts a negative spin on everything including; the way you see yourself, the situations you encounter and your expectations for the future. Try to replace negative thoughts with more balanced thoughts, for example:

- **Think outside yourself:** ask yourself if you'd say what you're thinking about yourself to someone else. If not, stop being so hard on yourself. Think about less harsh statements that offer more realistic description
- **Allow yourself to be less than perfect:** many depressed people are perfectionists, holding themselves to impossibly high standards and then beating themselves up when they fail to meet them. Battle this source of self-imposed stress by challenging your negative ways of thinking
- **Socialise with positive people:** notice how people who always look on the bright side deal with challenges, even minor ones, like not being able to find a parking space. Then consider how you would react in the same situation. Even if you have to pretend, try to adopt their optimism and persistence in the face of difficulty
- **Keep a negative thought log:** whenever you experience a negative thought, jot down the thought and what triggered it in a notebook. Review your log when you're in a good mood. Consider if the negativity

was truly warranted. Ask yourself if there's another way to view the situation. For example, let's say your boyfriend or girlfriend was short with you and you automatically assumed that the relationship was in trouble. It's possible he or she may be just having a bad day.

Additional coping strategies

Turn to friends and family members who make you feel loved and cared for: spend time talking and listening face-to-face with trusted people and share what you're going through. The people you talk to don't have to be able to fix you; they just need to be good listeners. Ask for the help and support you need. You may have retreated from your most treasured relationships, but emotional connection can get you through this tough time.

Try to keep up with social activities even if you don't feel like it: often when you're depressed, it feels more comfortable to retreat into your shell, but being around other people may improve your mood.

Join a support group for depression: being with others dealing with depression can go a long way in reducing your sense of isolation. You can also encourage each other, give and receive advice on how to cope and share your experiences.

Exercise is a powerful tool for dealing with depression: major studies show that regular exercise can be as effective as antidepressant medication at increasing energy levels and decreasing feelings of fatigue.

Practice relaxation techniques: daily relaxation practice can help relieve symptoms of depression, reduce stress, and boost feelings of joy and well-being. Try yoga, deep breathing, progressive muscle relaxation or meditation.

In order to overcome depression, you have to do things that relax and energise you: this includes following a healthy lifestyle, learning how to better manage stress, setting limits on what you're able to do, adopting healthy habits and scheduling fun activities into your day.

Aim for eight hours of sleep: depression typically involves sleep problems. Whether you're sleeping too little or too much, your mood suffers. Get on a better sleep schedule by learning healthy sleep habits.

Expose yourself to a little sunlight every day: lack of sunlight can make depression worse. Make sure you're getting enough. Take a short walk outdoors, have your coffee outside, enjoy an al fresco meal, people-watch on a park bench, or sit out in the garden.

Aim for at least 15 minutes of sunlight a day to boost your mood. If you live somewhere with little winter sunshine, try using a light therapy box.

Care for a pet: while nothing can replace the human connection, pets can bring joy and companionship into your life and help you feel less isolated. Caring for a pet can also get you outside of yourself and give you a sense of being needed, both powerful antidotes to depression.

Do things you enjoy (or used to): pick up a former hobby or a sport you used to like. Express yourself creatively through music, art, or writing. Go out with friends. Push yourself to do things, even when you don't feel like it. You might be surprised at how much better you feel once you're out in the world.

3

Road to recovery

Develop your 'wellness toolbox'

Come up with a list of things that you can do for a quick mood boost. Include any strategies, activities, or skills that have helped in the past. Try and implement a few of these ideas each day, even if you're feeling good.

- List what you like about yourself
- Read a good book or look at a magazine with pictures
- Watch a funny film or TV show
- Take a long hot bath, manicure your nails or massage your hands and feet
- Tackle a few small tasks that are achievable, that don't take a lot of energy or focus
- Play with or groom a pet
- Talk to friends or family face-to-face
- Listen to music
- Do a crossword or word search, colouring, knitting or jigsaw puzzle.

The importance of diet

- **Don't skip meals:** going too long between meals can make you feel irritable and tired, so aim to eat something at least every three to four hours
- **Minimise sugar and refined carbohydrates:** you may crave sugary snacks, baked goods or comfort foods such as pasta or chips, but these feel-good foods quickly lead to a crash in mood and energy
- **Focus on complex carbohydrates:** foods such as baked potatoes, whole wheat pasta, oatmeal and whole grain breads can boost serotonin levels without a crash
- **Boost your vitamins and minerals:** deficiencies in vitamins and minerals such as folic acid and B-12 can contribute to depression. Take a B-complex vitamin supplement or eat more citrus fruit, leafy greens, beans, chicken and eggs
- **Fluids and Hydration:** drink water during the day. It is best to be guided by your thirst but when you are feeling depressed you may forget to drink. Have a regular break to drink or keep a water bottle with you. Avoid drinking alcohol as whilst this may make your mood feel better this will only be temporarily. In the longer term alcohol can make your depression worse along with your physical health. Excessive caffeine should be avoided; coffee and tea along with some carbonated and energy drinks contain caffeine, this can give a short term boost but can disturb your sleep and cause mood swings.

Common triggers

Depression is highly treatable and effective interventions are available. As part of your recovery it is important to be aware of triggers and how they can impact upon your mood.

Common triggers include:

- **Not following a treatment plan.** Stopping medication due to side effects or believing that you are now better. It is important to discuss any medication concerns with your doctor before you make any changes to your medication regime. Despite feeling better, you will need to remain on your medication for a specific length of time in order to fully recover from your depression and should always discuss this with your doctor.
- **Not practising or completing any therapeutic techniques** advised as part of your therapeutic intervention towards achieving recovery.
- **Dwelling on your supposed flaws and failures.** Viewing life through a negative lens. It is more productive and beneficial to focus on positive aspects.
- **Knowing your own personal vulnerabilities.** Learn how to recognise the who, what, why's and when's of your emotional and physical life. Look at your calendar for potentially difficult periods such as anniversaries, divorce, and death/loss. Highlight these days to allow

yourself to anticipate and plan for any potential threats to your depression recovery. What circumstances may affect your mood and behaviour. Do you feel supported?

Check in with your physical state, be mindful of yourself, and check your sleep, appetite, concentration, energy levels.

Warning signs

It is important to think about any symptoms you may have experienced prior to seeking support and treatment for your depression. For example, did you feel more tearful? Did you feel more irritable or anxious? Creating a checklist can assist in your monitoring how you are feeling on a regular basis. This is a great way of helping you to manage your own recovery, it will assist in building your confidence and is a great help in noticing any early warning signs.

Checklist of symptoms experienced in the past:

Crisis planning

Having a prevention or crisis plan is critical to help you manage your recovery. Depression can be a chronic illness but with a good prevention plan in place, it is often possible to prevent recurrence entirely or limit the severity and duration if depression does return. Monitor your past symptoms, reflect on how you are and be stress aware.

Learning to recognise your own triggers and symptoms helps you to maintain control. Think ahead and talk with friends, family or your GP for early support. This will help you to manage crisis episodes more effectively.

List possible contacts you have who could help with early support:

4

Dealing with setbacks

When people are depressed they often have a negative way of looking at themselves, the world and their futures. Some believe that negative thinking is one of the important factors in ensuring their depression continues. It clouds the way they interpret situations and helps ensure they continue to have a negative outlook on life.

When people feel depressed or low, they often stop being as active as normal and spend less time socialising or engaging in their hobbies. This means that they have less pleasure in their lives and little to look forward to on a day to day basis, which too can keep them feeling low. When they are inactive it normally leads to them feeling even more lethargic, which makes it even more difficult to escape this trap and a vicious cycle occurs.

People who are depressed or low often spend a lot of time lying in bed or sitting around watching TV. Often this leads to people feeling as though they have wasted their day and have achieved very little which makes them feel even worse. It also leaves them with plenty of time to beat themselves up or worry about their problems, which of course also makes them feel worse.

Using the tools from your 'wellness toolbox' and setting goals on your activity scheduler are a positive way of moving forwards again.

Additional activity schedule

	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday
What time did you get up?			
Breakfast			
Morning			
Lunch			
Afternoon			
Dinner			
Evening			
What time did you go to bed?			

Thursday	Friday	Saturday	Sunday

Concerns and complaints

If you have any concerns, complaints or comments about your experience of our service then please tell a member of the team or contact the Patient Advice and Liaison Service on 0800 328 7971.

Notes

Developed by

Julie Bull RMN
Janet Winter O.T.
Leah Marriner Research Assistant

These booklets were created specifically to assist our set 4 follow up sessions identified for clients following assessment, to assist with understanding of symptoms, learning strategies to promote coping, facilitate recovery and promote well-being. We have received some wonderful feedback from clients and clinicians during the developmental stages which has been incorporated into the booklets.

If you would like to have information translated into a different language, please contact the Equality and Diversity Team at: EqualityandInclusion@oxfordhealth.nhs.uk

Arabic يُرجى الاتصال بنا إذا كنتم ترغبون في الحصول على المعلومات بلغة أخرى أو بتسبيق مختلف.

Bengali আপনি এই তথ্য অন্য ভাষায় বা আলাদা আকারে পেতে চাইলে অনুগ্রহ করে আমাদের সাথে যোগাযোগ করুন।
Urdu اگر آپ یہ معلومات دیگر زبان یا مختلف فارمیٹ میں چاہتے ہیں تو برائے مہربانی ہم سے رابطہ کریں۔

Chinese 若要以其他語言或格式提供這些資訊，請與我們聯繫

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Oxford Health NHS Foundation Trust
Trust Headquarters
Littlemore Mental Health Centre
Sandford Road
Oxford
OX4 4XN

Switchboard 01865 901 000
Email enquiries@oxfordhealth.nhs.uk
Website www.oxfordhealth.nhs.uk

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